executioners, stave, sword, kettledrum and standard bearers in their many-horned and pointed scarlet caps, clearing the way by choking it up, restoring order by creating confusion. A clattering array of Afghaun horse followed them, beplumed and armed cap-a-pie, their kettledrums beating, and their bossed and ornamented furniture jingling as they swept past, followed by a host of bare-legged, long-haired groom-boy runners. After them pranced a squadron of the Envoy's body-guard, in blue and silver, and then – Majesty itself.

The Shah was splendidly mounted, sat well and upright, and looked every inch of him the King. The imperial velvet crown, with drooping leaves of emerald pendants branching from the upper part of it, encircled his high brow, which glistened in a band of costly gems. His dress was a tight-fitting purple satin tunic, embroidered in gold and precious stones, and from shoulder to wrist were bound armlets of massive plates of jewellery. Shagreen leather, pointed-toed and iron-heeled boots, and a flat compact cashmere shawl girdle, from which was suspended a splendid Isfahan scimitar, completed his attire. The Shah was a man of great personal beauty, and so well got up that none could have guessed his age. The character of his countenance was one of excessive hauteur, blended with melancholy; an expression which was increased tenfold by his regularly marked eyebrows, long dark eyes, and beard of jettest black.

Rattray was dazzled, and noted that the people of Kabul were not uninterested: 'As the royal train swept on through the narrow winding streets, every window, doorway and roof was crowded with spectators.' But they were not cheering the man they called 'the Firangi's King'. Instead they showed no sign of 'pleasure or loyalty' but merely looked on 'mute and dogged, counting their beads as they stood motionless, with arms crossed over their breasts. The silence was unbroken save for the voice of a petitioner driven back in an attempt to reach the royal ear, the tramp of cavalry, and the shout of the officer proclaiming the power, excellence and majesty of the Shah of Shahs, the pearl of the Durrani dynasty.' Another officer-turned-artist, Lockyer Willis Hart, went further: 'This form and ceremony, so hateful to the Affghans, was the King's foible, and was sometimes carried to an absurd extent.'[75]

It was not just the people on the street. Many of the chiefs also felt humiliated and belittled by the grandeur and distance of Shuja's ultra-royal style: 'By the late ruler the nobles were treated very attentively, almost on equal terms and enjoyed much influence,' recorded Colonel Wade's munshi, Shahamat Ali, 'while now . . . they found it very difficult to obtain admittance to the royal presence; and those who by flattering the ushers could do so, were made to stand at a respectful distance from his Majesty with their hands folded in a most humble manner, and often compelled to retire from the durbar without being allowed to say a word to the King.'[76] It was also this that made the British officers of Shuja's Contingent so loath to